The object: what exists, and what we make

Verdict

Make one jewellery-scale locket for couples, and sell it as a locket, never as a "photo watch". Nothing like it surfaced in Korea, the US or the UK. The nearest products are $9 to $30 photo pocket watches for dads and groomsmen, and at the top a $149 mechanical watch with a photo holder.

So the design has to look different even in a thumbnail:

- **Smaller:** 36 mm, where photo watches run about 46 mm.
- **Hidden:** a colour photo inside, not a black-and-white etching on the lid.
- **Stopped:** hands fixed at your moment.
- **Written:** one line of each person's letter, in their own handwriting, inside the lid.

Price it in the band where Korean couples already spend. Mid-range couple rings cost ₩100,000 to ₩300,000 each, and people in their 20s call ₩100,000 to ₩130,000 a fitting anniversary gift, and spend about ₩271,600 on each anniversary (2023 survey). Lead with the pair at ₩139,000, next to the $85 to $140 pair price of long-distance bracelets such as Totwoo and Bond Touch.

Confidence that no direct competitor exists is medium-low. The search index covers Coupang, Naver Shopping and Kakao gifts poorly, so search those three by hand; it is on this week's list.

What already exists

Twenty products that set the look, the price and the expectations. There are no product photos here: the research tool could search the web but could not open pages, so it could not copy pictures. Tap a name to see the photos on the shop's own page; some names open a search page, so scroll for the item named. With five minutes, open these first: the Amazon photo watch (what to avoid), the Charles Hubert watch (the quality bar), the Abbott Lyon locket (the price and the secret engraving), the Idus mini locket (the Korean price) and Truest North (a needle that points to a place). Prices come from search results, not opened pages, and may have changed.

Product	What it is	Price	Take or avoid
Photo watch · Amazon photo pocket watches	About 46 mm, quartz, a black-and-white photo etched on the lid, sold for dads and groomsmen; dozens of near-identical listings	About $27	Avoid looking like this
Photo watch · Charles Hubert photo pocket watch	Mechanical hunter case with a photo holder and an engraved cover; the top of the photo-watch range	About $149	The bar for hinge, glass and finish
Photo watch · SHOWROOM photo pocket watch	47 mm corporate-gift photo watch on a stand; Korea's nearest item	₩59,000	The ceiling for anything called a "watch" in Korea
Photo watch · Idus pocket-watch pendants	Vintage pocket-watch pendant	₩28,000	The local look-alike
Locket · Abbott Lyon Photo Love Locket	Gold-plated steel locket with a photo and a secret engraving inside	From £89, about $118	The fashion-locket model; its secret engraving is our handwriting ring
Locket · Monica Rich Kosann lockets	Heirloom sterling lockets with two photos; the designer tier	$245 to $475	Lockets can be heirlooms
Locket · Lisa Angel photo locket	Plated locket; the buyer emails a photo; 1.4M+ orders on its storefront	£8 photo add-on	Collect and crop photos online for the buyer
Locket · silkpursesowsear brass locket	Solid brass with the photo on the metal		The material reference: warm, vintage, handmade

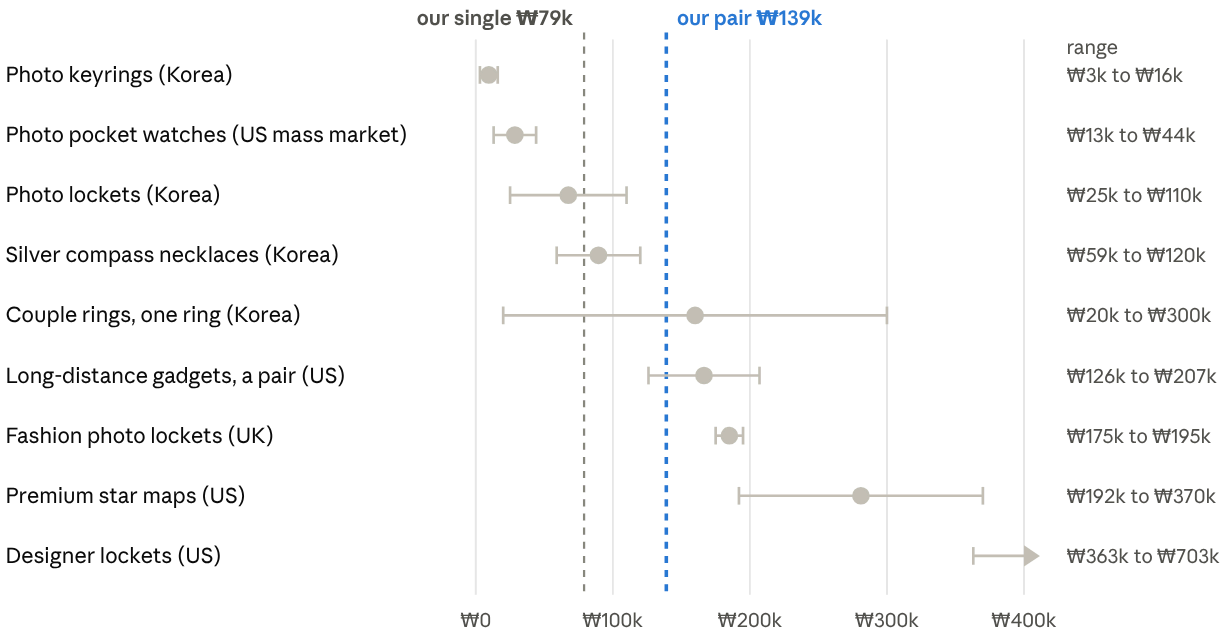
Product	What it is	Price	Take or avoid
Locket · Idus mini photo locket	Mini locket with photo and engraving, made in 4 to 6 days; sellers warn the snap is fragile	About ₩25,000	A sturdy hinge is a selling point
Compass · "I'd be lost without you" necklaces	Small compass pendant sold on a message card; a Walmart best-seller tag	$13 to $80	Romantic compasses still point north
Compass · Truest North	GPS compass whose needle points to a place you choose; Kickstarter and press	From $180	Proof that "points to a place" sells; ours needs no battery
Compass · Korean silver compass necklaces	925 silver vintage compass pendants	₩59,000 to ₩120,000	The local compass price
The moment · The Night Sky	The sky over a chosen place on a chosen date; 10.1K Trustpilot reviews	$39 print	A frozen moment sells; show a live preview before payment
The moment · Under Lucky Stars	Premium star maps	$130 to $250	A premium holds when the object is computed from the couple's own data
The moment · Korean constellation frames	Zodiac templates, not a real date and place	₩14,000 to ₩59,500	No date-accurate sky in Korea yet
Long distance · Lovebox	A box whose heart spins when a message arrives; 85,000+ of the classic sold, about €6M revenue in 2020	$130 to $175, plus $4.99 a month	Couples pay for an object plus a ritual

Product	What it is	Price	Take or avoid
Long distance · Totwoo touch bracelets	Bracelets that light and buzz when the other is touched	$85 to $140 a pair	The pair-price anchor; needs charging
Korean couples · Couple rings	Entry and mid-range brands such as 로이드; the main couple-jewellery budget	₩20,000 to ₩300,000 a ring	The budget we compete with
Military couples · 곰신 letter paper	Letter paper with both names, by service branch; many reviews, and a military-couple app sells its own	₩5,500	Military couples already buy things for their letters, but cheap ones
Charms · Photo keyrings	Acrylic photo charms, some with NFC	₩3,000 to ₩16,000	Charms are cheap; ours must read as jewellery

Where the gap is

At ₩139,000, the pair sits with couple rings and long-distance gifts

Price range for each kind of product, in won; US and UK prices converted



search results, Oct 2026 · listing price ranges, not averages · ₩1,480 to the dollar, £1 ≈ $1.33 · designer lockets run off the scale to ₩703k

The gap is not a price; it is a product. Nobody sells a jewellery-scale locket that is computed from a couple's own moment, the way star maps are, and nobody joins a keepsake to a letter that opens only when both have written. Photo watches are cheap because they are generic, and the pair can charge couple-ring prices only if it never looks generic.

Our design: one small body, two faces, a sealed card

These are concept renders drawn for this plan, not photographs of a made sample. The samples decide the final piece.



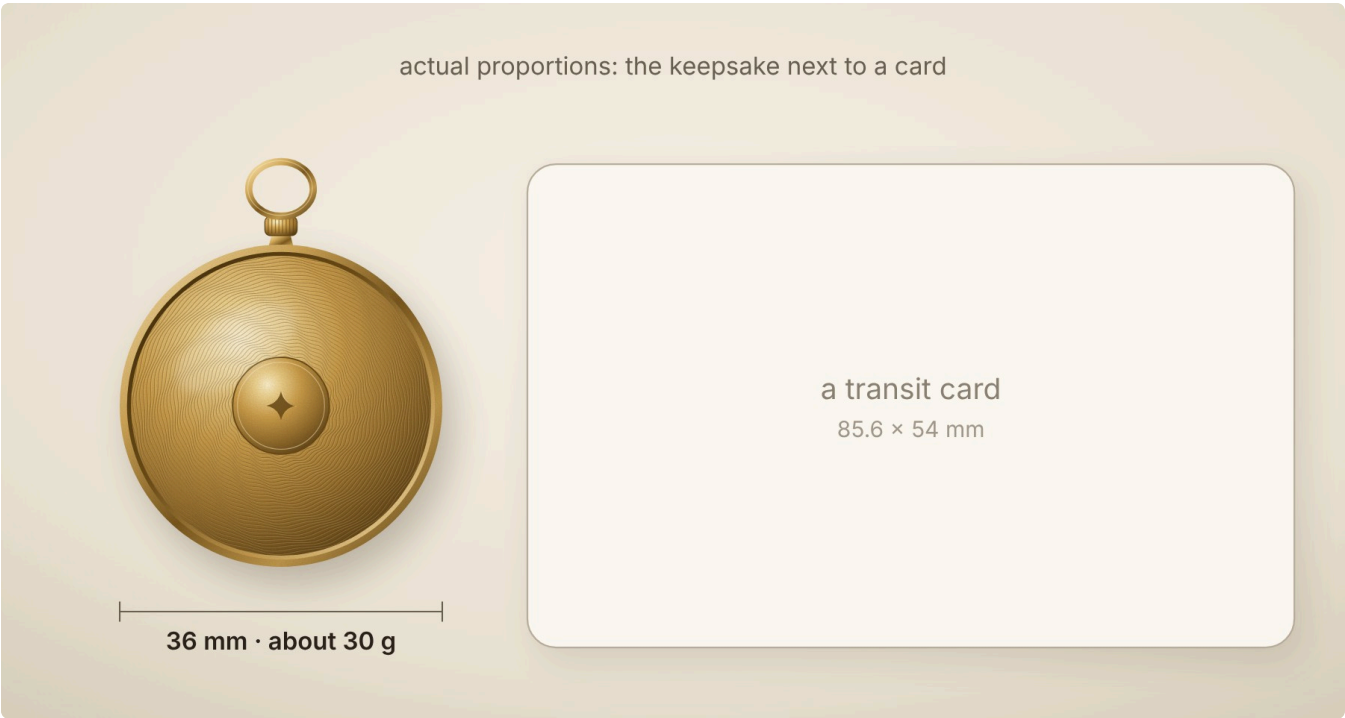
Open, the lid holds your own photo under domed glass, ringed by one line from each of your letters, engraved in each person's own handwriting. The face holds the moment, its hands stopped at 11:11 or at the time you choose. That ring of handwriting is what makes the letter part of the object, and it is what a copycat can't make.



Two faces on one body. The watch face suits most couples. The needle face is for distance: it is set to the bearing from your city to theirs.



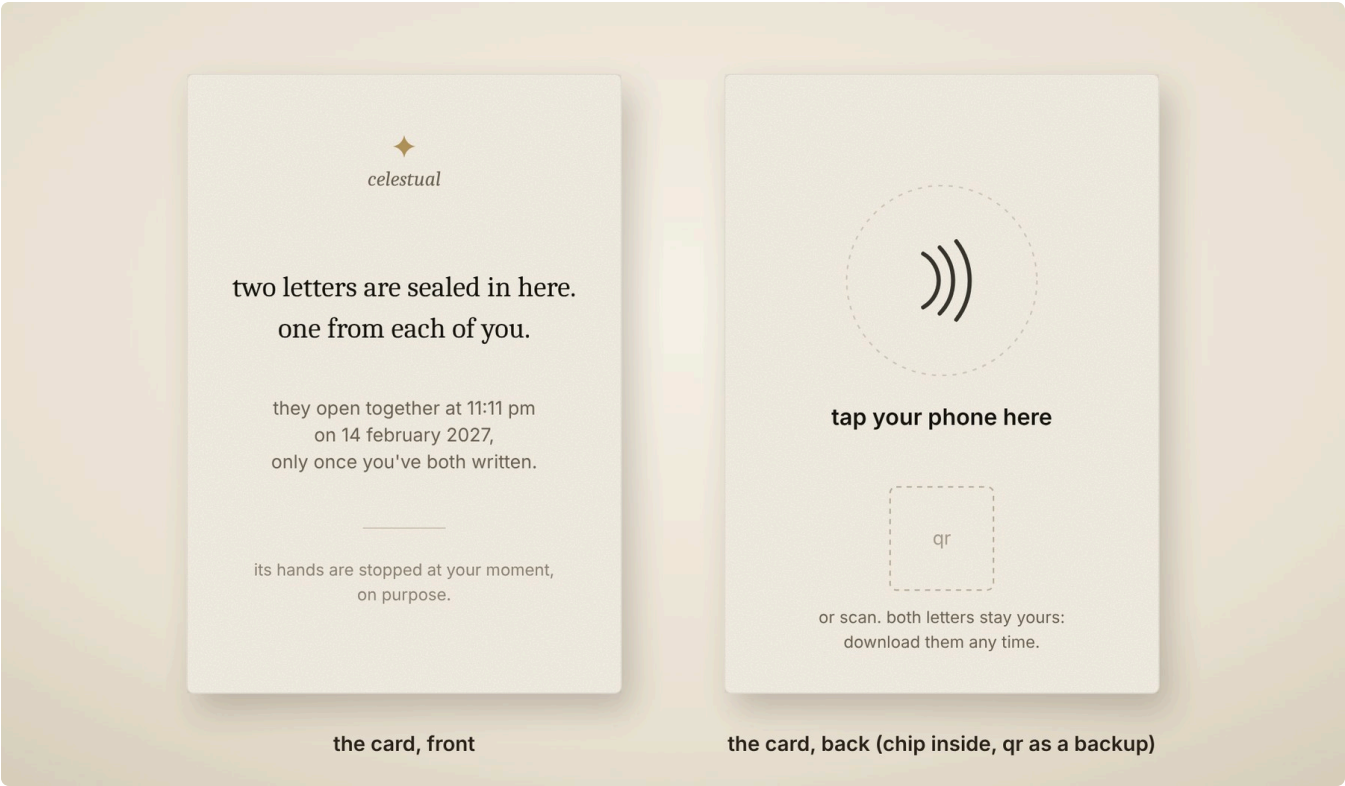
Outside, the lid is engine-turned brass. The back carries one engraved line and the sky over your city that night; the stars drawn here are illustrative.



Size: 36 mm across and about 30 g, small enough for a bag charm or a necklace.



The box opens in three beats: the box, the sealed letters, the click of the lid. That is also the shot list for every unboxing video.



The card explains why the hands don't move, and holds the chip that opens both letters online, with the QR as a backup.

Part	Spec	Why
Case	Brass hunter case, 34 to 38 mm, about 30 g, hinged at 9 o'clock	Light enough for a bag; quiet outside, antique inside

Part	Spec	Why
Finish	Hand-patinated brass under a clear e-coat (the base cost), or a silver-tone, nickel-free plating of 1 to 2 microns for about ₩2,000 to ₩4,000 more; lead under 0.05% and cadmium under 0.01% in every metal part, tested for nickel release	The content test picks between the two finishes
Dial	Cream, Roman numerals, blued hands glued at the chosen time; no movement	No battery to die, $2 to $5 cheaper, about 3 mm thinner
Photo	The couple's own, trimmed like a photo-booth frame, under domed mineral glass; the window is about 26 to 30 mm, so the crop guide must fit two faces	No printing, no photo moderation, and it can be swapped after a breakup
Inside the lid	One line from each person's letter, laser-engraved in their own handwriting, around the photo. No quote yet; if it isn't legible on a sample, the two lines go on a printed card behind the photo	Joins the free letter to the paid object; a copy can't engrave your partner's sealed words
Back	One engraved line; the back has room for 3 to 4 lines of about 20 Latin letters, or 2 lines of 10 to 12 Hangul. The sky is an option	The personal part, done in Seoul
Chain	Short chain with a trigger clasp	Switches between bag charm and necklace
Box	Matte black drawer box, cream insert, wax-sealed envelope	Three beats on camera, no glare
Card	Paper card with an NFC chip and a QR backup	A metal case blocks the chip, so it lives in the card

Decisions still open, and what settles each

One is already made: it is sold as a locket, not a watch. The rest are decided by a test, not by taste.

Decision	Options	Settled by	When
Price of the pair	₩119,000 or ₩139,000	The pair test shows each price at random, if the lawyer allowed sign-ups; compare taps. Otherwise the Wadiz waitlist decides after discharge	31 Jan
The face	Watch stopped at your moment, or the needle that points to you	Which one earns more "where can I buy" comments and DMs per 1,000 views	Dec to Jan
The finish	Silver-tone, or hand-patinated brass	The same content test, one post each	Dec to Jan
Size	34, 36 or 38 mm; 36 mm is the working size	Samples in hand: does the 26 to 30 mm photo window fit two faces?	First samples
Handwriting inside	Laser-engraved handwriting, or a printed line	Legibility on a sample at that size, and its cost	First samples
An entry item	A ₩29,000 to ₩39,000 brass 11:11 charm for Pepero Day, 100 days and friends	A one-question poll of pair-letter users if the lawyer allowed sign-ups; otherwise the waitlist after discharge	Dec to Jan
The opening time for military couples	11:11 am on a weekend or holiday	Already decided by phone rules: soldiers can use phones only 18:00 to 21:00 on weekdays and 08:30 to 21:00 on weekends and holidays	Now

In Branch A there are no samples before discharge. The face and finish posts use the concept renders, each labelled "concept, not made yet", and run only if the lawyer allowed posts about the object. Otherwise these choices wait for the first samples after discharge.

Making, selling and shipping

Verdict

Seoul has no pocket-watch case makers, so the first 100 to 300 pieces should use a semi-custom brass case blank from a Chinese factory. Everything personal is done in Seoul: the dial set to the couple's time, the photo, both engravings, the checks and the packing. The label will most likely still say "Made in China", because finishing in Seoul does not usually change where a product is from. Say "finished by hand in Seoul", never "made in Korea", unless customs confirms it.

By estimate, not quote, that costs about ₩34,400 for a single and ₩62,800 for a pair. No supplier has quoted yet, and your own hours on each order are not counted. From the purchase order to 100 sellable pieces takes about eight weeks.

Two rules before any order. **Numbers in the order, not "lead-free":** lead under 0.05% by weight in every metal part, cadmium under 0.01%, and nickel-free plating, backed by mill certificates and a lab test. Free-machining and many casting brasses hold 1.8 to 3.7% lead, and brass sold as lead-free can still be over a jewellery limit. **Nothing is ordered before discharge.**

Route	Cost per case	Time	Minimum	Verdict
A. Semi-custom brass case from a Chinese factory, finished in Seoul	About $4 to $8	About 8 weeks from order to 100 pieces	100 to 300	**The default**
B. Lost-wax casting in Jongno from your own 3D model	About ₩10,000 to ₩25,000, 2 to 4 times route A	12 to 16 weeks	No formal minimum	Later, for a shape only you own
C. Stock watch pendants from Alibaba	About $1.50 to $2.50	2 to 4 weeks	10 to 100	Reference samples only; it looks like the commodity

Case prices are listing prices and estimates from search results, not quotes. The first real quotes replace them.

Who makes what

Get at least three quotes for each part. Prices exclude VAT; most are listing prices or estimates.

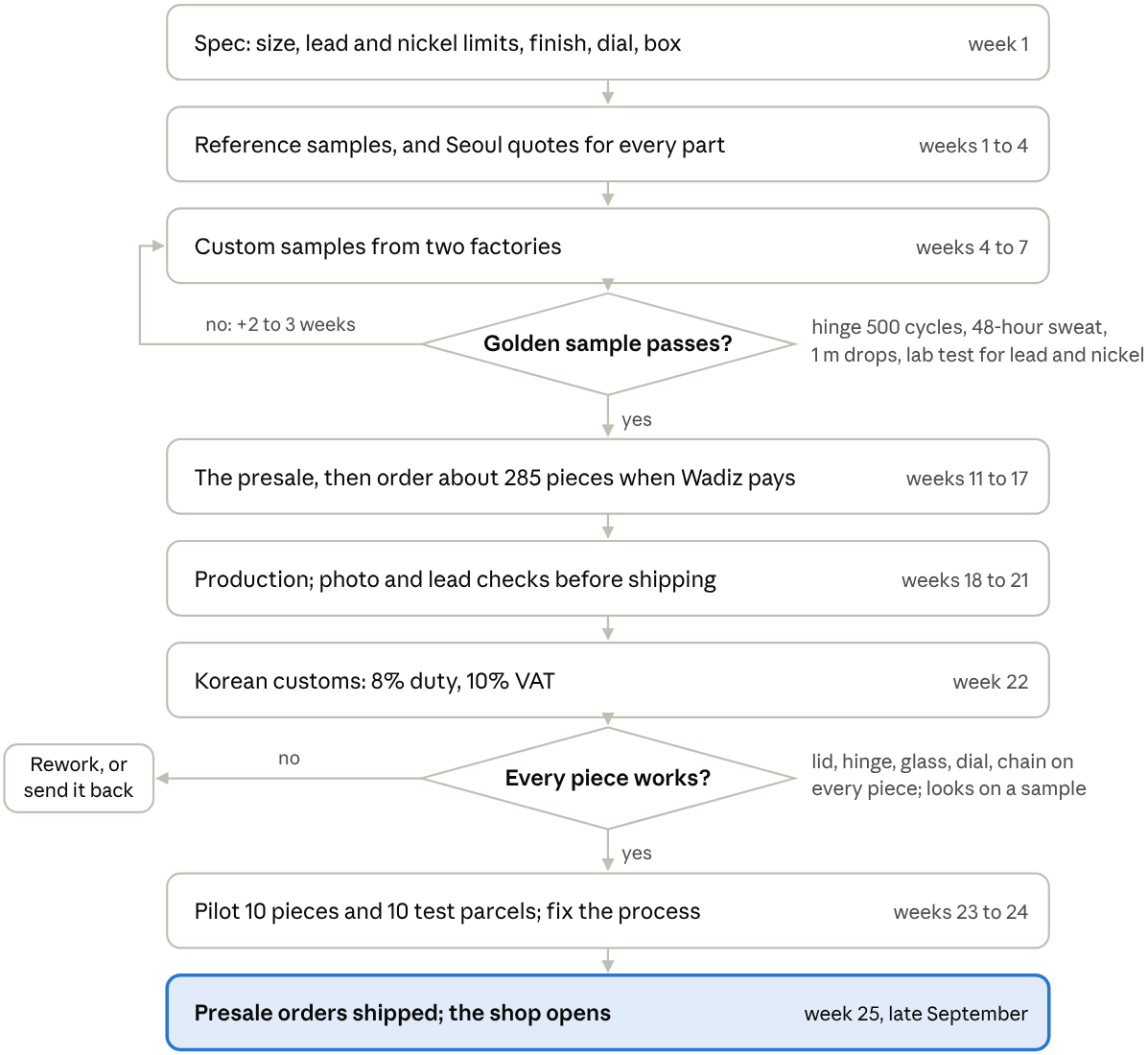
Part	Where	Minimum	Price at 100	Lead time
Brass hunter case blank, semi-custom	Factories in Guangzhou or Yiwu through Alibaba or 1688, via a Korean buying agent	100 to 300	$4 to $8	3 to 5 weeks, plus a week of freight
Reference samples: stock watch pendants and lockets	Alibaba, AliExpress, 1688	10 to 100	$1.50 to $2.50	2 to 4 weeks
Cream Roman dial	A Chinese dial printer, or printed in Seoul	10 to 50	$0.30 to $1.00	1 to 3 weeks
Fixed hands	Chinese watch-parts suppliers; parts dealers in Jongno 4-ga	About 100 pairs	$0.05 to $0.30 a pair	1 to 2 weeks
Domed glass, two per piece	China, or craft suppliers in Dongdaemun	10 to 100	₩100 to ₩500 each	Days to 2 weeks
Chain, trigger clasp and rings	The accessory-parts floor of Dongdaemun Jonghap Market	By the pack	₩1,000 to ₩3,500 a set	Days
Clear coat, or a thin gold flash	Plating shops in Jongno, or the factory	A lot minimum by weight	Coat ₩300 to ₩1,500; gold flash ₩2,000 to ₩4,000 more	3 to 7 days

Part	Where	Minimum	Price at 100	Lead time
Engraving, back and inside the lid	Laser shops in Seoul, or your own fibre laser later (₩2.7M to ₩4.0M)	1	₩2,000 to ₩5,000 a piece for a short line (estimate)	Same day to 3 days
NFC chip (NTAG213)	nowwin, KOREA NFC	1	₩250 to ₩610	1 to 7 days
Letter card and envelope	Korean online printers	About 100	₩300 to ₩1,000 a set	3 to 7 days
Wax seal sticker	Sodastamp	1	₩350 to ₩460	About a week
Drawer box, custom	Packative, Betterbox, Box114 in Seoul; Bangsan market only from about 1,000	50 to 100	₩8,000 to ₩20,000	2 to 4 weeks
Lab tests: lead, cadmium, nickel	KTR, KCL, KATRI, FITI or KOTITI	Per sample	₩200,000 to ₩1M for the first set (₩500,000 in the launch budget)	1 to 3 weeks

Imported parts pay 8% Korean duty and 10% VAT on their landed value, and goods for resale need a formal import declaration whatever their value.

From sample to the first batch

About 25 weeks from discharge to buyers' hands, with two checks that can send you back

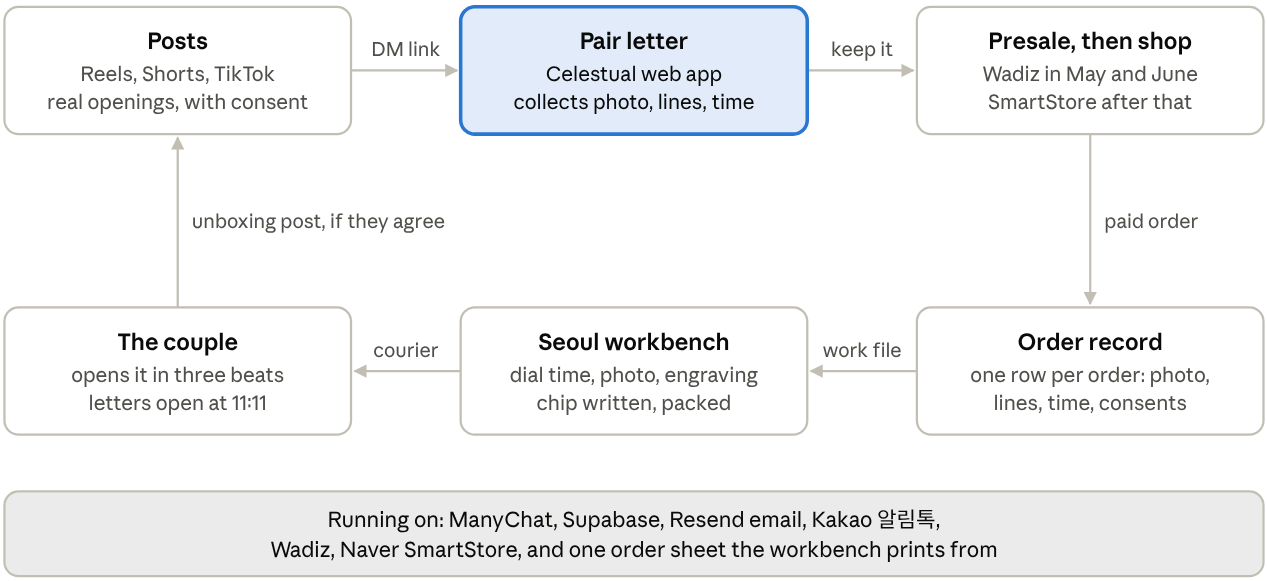


production path · route A, weeks counted from discharge in early April 2027

In the default plan this starts in the week of discharge, early April 2027. The golden sample is approved in week 8, the presale runs from 14 June to 11 July, and the batch is ordered once Wadiz pays out, about two weeks later. With about eight weeks from order to finished pieces, the first pieces reach buyers in late September, and the presale page promises 8 October, two weeks to spare. Allow one extra sample loop of 2 to 3 weeks, and move every later date with it. The plan takes no faster route: ordering before discharge would mean a shop run for you while you serve.

The operations stack

One loop: the letter collects what the object needs, every delivery becomes a post



operations loop · from the first post to the next post

The pair letter does the work competitors do by hand: it collects the photo, crops it to the window, records the time to set and the line each person wrote, and takes both people's consent. Each order then arrives at the workbench as one complete row, with nothing to chase by message. Supabase and Resend are already part of Celestual, so the only new systems are Wadiz, SmartStore and the order sheet. The order step itself is built in Phase 4, two weeks before the presale.

Shipping, returns and service

A boxed locket weighs about 150 to 300 g. Start with Korea Post or convenience-store parcels, and move to a fulfilment company only when packing takes more than a day a week.

Option	Price	When to use it
GS25 or CU half-price parcel, store to store	₩1,800 to ₩1,900 up to 500 g	Cheapest; the buyer collects from a convenience store
Korea Post counter	₩4,000	Home delivery at low volume

Option	Price	When to use it
Courier contract for a small seller	About ₩2,500 to ₩3,500	Home delivery once volume is steady
Fulfilment company, all-in (FASSTO and others)	₩2,700 to ₩3,500 an order	Past about 30 orders a week
Returns	₩3,000 each way; the seller pays for defects	

Service rules:

1. State the delivery date on every page and in every presale reward.
2. Answer within 24 hours; replace a defective piece first and ask questions later.
3. Take back defects for 3 months, and refund within 3 business days of the return arriving.
4. Delete the photo when the 3-month defect window closes, and say so before the upload.
5. Before payment, show the separate notice and the unticked consent box for personalised goods.

The US, later. Start on Etsy with 10 to 20 test orders, once there are 50 or more Korean reviews.

- **Shipping:** EMS costs about ₩23,000 to ₩26,000 for 0.5 kg, or from about ₩16,390 through a consolidator with duty prepaid.
- **Duty:** Korean-made goods have paid about 12.5% since 24 July 2026. A case made in China may still count as Chinese, which costs more.
- **Before the first US order,** get a free binding ruling from US Customs on the tariff code (imitation jewellery, 7117.19.90) and on origin.
- **A US fulfilment and engraving partner** makes sense only past 100 to 200 US orders a month.

The 11:11

Verdict

The group 11:11 stays as the free format and the brand's origin, but it is no longer the whole company. It runs only when a host commits in writing, it costs $0, and it is the test most plausibly legal while you serve, once the lawyer says so in writing.

Inside the master plan it has three jobs:

1. **Prove the format** in a closed group, against gates written in advance (the turnaround memo's Gate 1 and Gate 2).
2. **Make pairs.** A two-way "i like you" or "closer friends" is the start of a pair, and the pair letter is its natural next step: offered after the night, never during it.
3. **Feed content and hosts.** Group recaps, shared with consent, bring the next group.

It is not a sales channel. Nothing is sold during a night, picks are never paid, and no romantic claim is made in marketing until Gate 2 says the romance is real.

The name is not Korean. 11:11 is the minute people make a wish everywhere. Korean student associations were only the cheapest first pilot, because you know their officers and 11.11 is Pepero Day. English labels are the default; Korean labels appear only for Korean groups.

How a night works

1. **A host commits in writing** to a night for a group with an active roster of 60 or more, with two named contacts.
2. **Save the date, then rehearse.** The host posts only a save-the-date. The join link reaches the group chat only after a rehearsal with 20 to 30 testers passes.
3. **Join.** A secret link, used once and tied to the member's Instagram account. Members give a birth year, 18 or older, or 19 for Korean groups, type a first name and last initial, and give an email for the result.
4. **Pick names, no text, in three kinds:**
    a. *thanks*: signed, up to 10, always delivered
    b. *closer friends*: sealed, up to 3
    c. *i like you*: sealed, up to 2

5. **Writing closes at 10:11 pm.** At 11:11 pm local, a sealed pick opens only if both chose the same kind for each other, privately, on the page and by email.
6. **Everyone opens something.** Officers make sure every member receives at least one signed thank-you, so nobody sees a bare zero.
7. **After.** The numbers the gates need are saved at 71 hours. One-way picks are deleted at 72 hours, and two-way pairs are anonymised after 14 days.

The full rules, including who can see what, safety and the one-person version, are in the turnaround memo, section "The one thing to build: 11:11, version 0".

Gates carried over from the turnaround memo

Gate 0, the live check, the pair-test bars and the switching rule go to the outside gatekeeper by 16 October and are frozen then; the night gates from the rehearsal on are frozen on 5 November. Nobody changes a threshold after that.

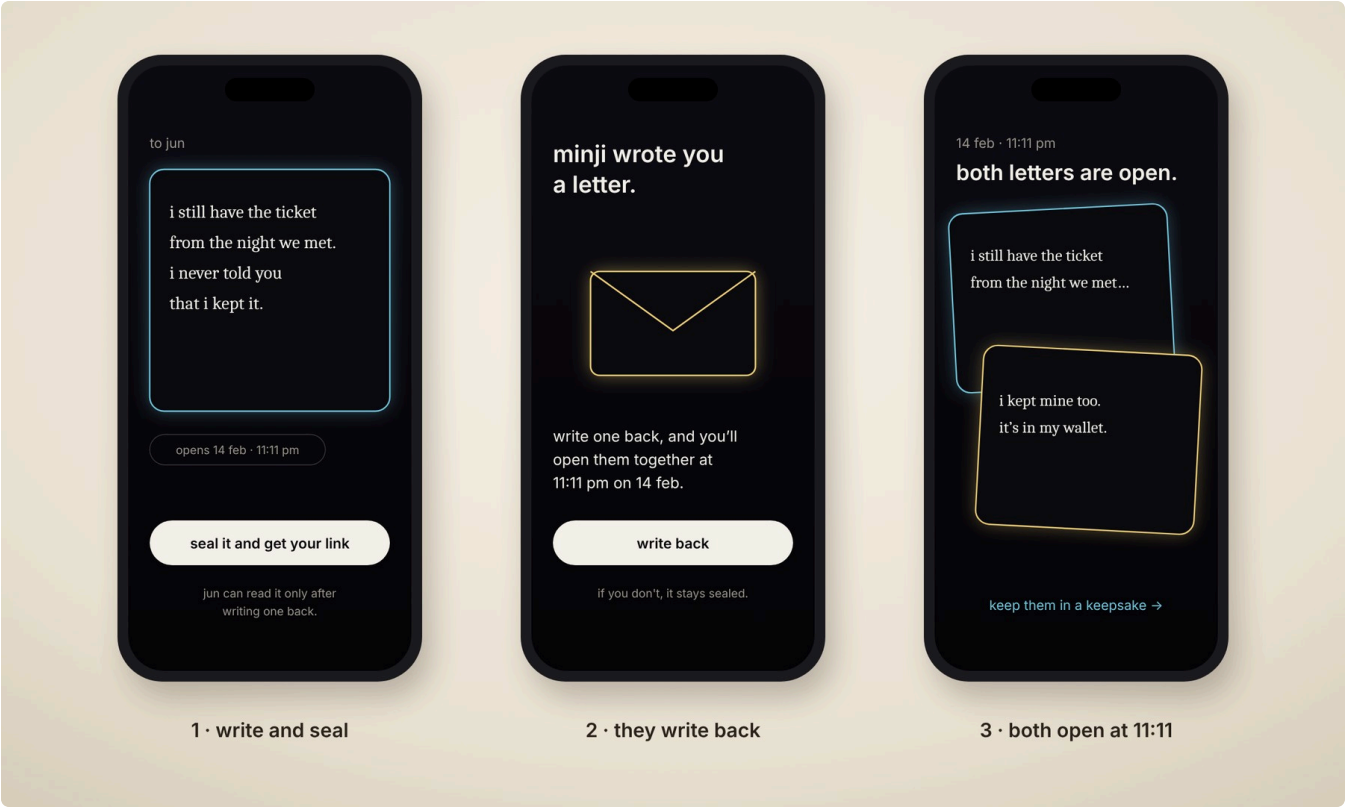
Gate	When	Passes if	Otherwise
Legal	21 Oct 2026	A written yes to free activity (Branch A)	No written answer yet, or barred: dormant until the answer or discharge (Branch 0). Gate 0 is held four days after the written yes
Gate 0: hosts	25 Oct, 21:00 KST	A host committed in writing to 11 November (roster 60 or more, two contacts), 3 hosts dated by 20 November, and the lawyer permits it	Any other case with one written host: nights from 20 November, which report results but decide nothing. No host: no nights in 2026, and pair letters start the next day
Live check	1 Nov	Joining and picking work in production, 3 hosts committed	The pilot moves to 20 November
Rehearsal	6 Nov, decided 8 Nov	80% of 20 to 30 testers join within 5 minutes, the reveal is on time	The pilot moves to 20 November

Gate	When	Passes if	Otherwise
Gate 1: does remote hosting work?	10 days after the third night	3 nights of 25 or more; a median 35% of the roster joins; 40% send a sealed pick; half say "do it again"	Median under 25%, or "do it again" under 35%: remote hosting stops, and in person becomes the next test
Gate 2: does the romance work?	1 Mar 2027	650 or more clean "i like you" picks, 10 or more clean pairs, at least 1.5 times as many mutual pairs as random picking would give, with the random count doubled to be safe	"Not proven yet": no romance-led marketing. At 1.2 times random or less, the romantic layer comes off
Is the format real?	June 2027	Groups rebook without being pitched and run nights without founder help	
Is it a company?	13 Dec 2027	40 or more groups ran a night, half with no founder help	Below the bar: the 11:11 runs as seasons, not as the company. Celestual is a side project only if the shop gate in February fails too

"Clean" leaves out the team, the officers, test links and couples who were already together. The first in-person night after discharge runs whatever the remote result, because in person is the real launch and has to be tested before anyone decides the company's fate.

One engine, two products

The group 11:11 and the pair letter are the same machine: something sealed, opened at 11:11 only when both sides have acted. Build it once; whichever test runs first pays for most of the other.



Concept screens for the pair letter, in the brand's existing night palette.

	Group 11:11	Pair letters
Who	Members of one closed group	Two people who already know each other
What is sealed	A pick: a name, in one of three kinds	A letter
It opens when	Both picked the same kind for each other	Both have written
When	11:11 pm on the group's night	11:11 pm on the date the pair chose, or 11:11 am on a weekend or holiday when either serves
If it isn't mutual	Nobody is told; one-way picks are deleted at 72 hours	The letter stays sealed and is deleted after 30 days
Shared code	Joining and age check, sealing, the timed reveal, the result email, deletion jobs, analytics	The same

	Group 11:11	Pair letters
Built only for it	The directory, the three kinds, officer tools	The share link, the date picker, the "keep it in an object" question if the lawyer allows it

If the pair letter is built first (no host at Gate 0), it takes 10 to 15 hours, and the 11:11 later reuses its sealing, reveal and deletion. If the pilot night goes first, the pair letter becomes an add-on of a few hours.

Unlocking only when both answer is not new. SumOne, Korea's leading couple app with about 1M daily users, shows each partner's daily answer only once both have answered. What no one offers is one sealed letter that opens at 11:11 on a date the pair picks, then becomes a brass object with both people's handwriting inside. So compete on the time lock and the object, don't add daily questions, and treat SumOne as a possible partner.